

Figure 4. Handmade embroidery by traditional weavers

I got a vivid sense of the city's pluralistic ethos in 2006. I was travelling there on a train from Delhi when terrorists struck Varanasi with bombs at multiple sites, including at the train station; many died. I was with my partner and two white American friends, both on their first visits to India. They seemed rattled, and I worried for their safety. What if Hindu-Muslim riots broke out? Should we abandon the trip and get off at an earlier stop? Despite my concerns, I persuaded my fellow travellers to continue. Worst case, we could stay holed up in our hotel. When we arrived, we found a part of the station cordoned off by the police, red stains on the floor. Our taxi driver had witnessed the explosions: flying body parts, screams, the ensuing melee. He had taken an injured man to the hospital. But our decision to continue turned out to be a good one—the city remained calm and we moved about freely. I felt proud of my fellow citizens.

Perhaps Shiva himself inspires the city's pluralistic ethos. Quite unlike other 'respectable' Hindu gods, he still betrays his pre-Aryan roots. 'He has none of the concern for purity, the love of the auspicious, the disdain of the polluted, the reverence for family, lineage, and status which are characteristically Hindu,' writes Eck. A half-naked ascetic yogi with shaggy hair, he dwells in the forest and is lord of the beasts, smokes ganja, hangs